BEFORE YOU BUY YOUR CHILD'S FIRST HORSE

A practical guide for parents who want to get started the right way.

From Lisa & Jennifer | The Keefe Team - JLA Realty

If your child has started asking for a horse, you may be wondering whether this is a passing interest or the beginning of something wonderful. Either way, buying a horse is a big commitment. The horse is only one part of the decision.

We love seeing families get involved with horses. We also know how much easier the experience can be when parents have realistic expectations before bringing one home. This guide is a starting point, not a substitute for working with a qualified instructor, veterinarian and experienced horse professional.

Start with lessons, not a purchase

Before shopping for a horse, give your child regular time around horses with a reputable instructor. Riding is only part of it. Your child should also learn how to catch, lead, groom, tack up and safely handle a horse on the ground.

Ask the instructor whether your child is ready for the responsibility of ownership.
Consider leasing or part-leasing a suitable lesson horse before buying.
Make sure at least one adult is prepared to take responsibility for care, costs and decisions.

The right first horse is not always the prettiest one

For a beginner, temperament, training, soundness and suitability matter more than color, pedigree or potential. An older, experienced horse with a steady disposition may be a much better match than a young horse that needs training. The general rule: the younger or more inexperienced the rider is, the older and more experienced the horse should be.

- Have your child's instructor help evaluate candidates and observe the horse being handled and ridden.
- See the horse in its normal environment; ask about its history, habits, medical needs and workload.
- Arrange an independent pre-purchase veterinary examination. It helps assess risk but cannot guarantee future soundness.
- Avoid buying a horse sight unseen or relying only on videos or a seller's description.

Know what horse ownership really costs
The purchase price may be the least expensive part of owning a horse over time. Make a monthly budget and leave room for emergencies. Costs vary widely by location, horse, facility and level of care.

- Board or property upkeep; hay, feed, supplements and bedding.
- Routine veterinary care, vaccinations, dental care, parasite management and farrier visits.
- Lessons, training, tack, helmets, grooming supplies, and equipment replacement.
- Trailer transport, insurance if appropriate, and an emergency veterinary fund.
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Parent check: Could you continue paying for the horse and caring for it if your child lost interest, got injured or left for college?

Boarding or keeping a horse at home?
Boarding at a reputable barn can give a first-time family access to instructors, experienced help and facilities. Ask exactly what is included in the board fee, who handles emergencies and whether there is reliable supervision.

Keeping a horse at home offers convenience, but it also means daily feeding and checks, facility maintenance, manure management, emergency planning and arranging backup care when you travel. Horses are social animals, so companionship and turnout should be part of the plan.

If you need horse property, check the practical details
This is where we can help with the real estate side. A property can have plenty of acreage but still be a poor fit for horses. Before making an offer, here's what we'd check:

- Whether deed restrictions, HOA rules, local ordinances and applicable land-use requirements allow your intended horse use.
- Usable land, safe fencing, reliable water, drainage, shelter and a workable feeding and turnout setup.
- Access for a truck and horse trailer, deliveries, veterinarians and emergency vehicles.
- Space for hay and equipment, manure handling and any riding area you hope to have.
- Costs to add or repair facilities, and whether proposed improvements are permitted.

There is no universal "right number of acres" for a horse. The answer depends on local rules, soil and pasture conditions, management and the number of horses. Confirm the specifics before buying.

Safety is everyone's responsibility
Horses are large animals with quick reactions. Even a quiet, experienced horse can spook. A properly fitted, certified equestrian helmet, appropriate boots, supervision and consistent handling rules are essential.

- Teach children to approach, lead, tie, groom and move around horses safely with qualified supervision.
- Have an emergency contact plan and know who can transport the horse if needed.
- Keep a veterinarian's number handy and learn to recognize changes in appetite, movement and behavior.
- Do not leave a child solely responsible for managing a horse or making medical decisions.

Get involved before you buy
One of the best ways to learn is to spend time with other horse families. Lessons, volunteering, clinics and youth programs can help your child discover which activities they enjoy and what owning a horse actually involves.

We are involved with the Parker County 4-H Horse Project. If your family is interested, ask us about the current program schedule, participation requirements and how to get connected. Please confirm enrollment and horse-access requirements with the local 4-H program; they can change.

Questions to answer as a family
- Is our child taking lessons consistently and enjoying horse care as well as riding?
- Who will feed, check and care for the horse every day, including holidays and vacations?
- What is our realistic monthly budget and emergency reserve?
- Who is our trusted instructor or horse professional?
- Will we board, lease first or keep a horse at home?
- If buying land, have we verified restrictions, facilities and improvement costs?

Our advice
Take your time. Find a good instructor, spend time at the barn and ask plenty of questions. A well-matched horse and a realistic plan will do far more for your child than rushing into a purchase.

If you're thinking about your child's first horse, or wondering whether your current property will work, we are happy to visit with you. We can help you think through the property side and connect you with the right questions to ask about getting started.

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Educational information only. Horse selection, veterinary care, safety instruction, land-use requirements and propertysuitability should be verified with appropriate qualified professionals and local authorities.